

UPSC GS-II / GS-III POLITY

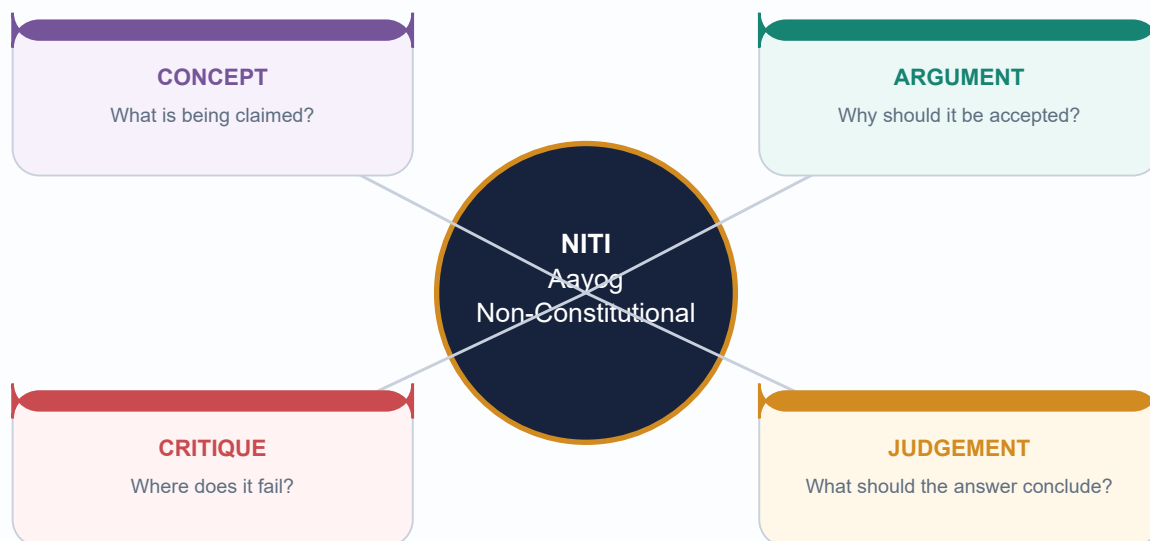
NITI Aayog Non-Constitutional, Non-Statutory Body

Indian Polity · GS Paper II / GS Paper III · Prelims + Mains

Integrated Basic + Advanced Course

13 deep-learning modules | Establishment to Answer-Writing

Prepared from the verified Polity knowledge base (basic/NITI-Aayog.md + advanced/34_NITI-Aayog.md)



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

1. Origin & Establishment

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Indian Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

Whenever cooperative federalism or planning architecture is debated, the 2014–15 replacement of the Planning Commission by NITI Aayog is the reference point.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The 65-year-old Planning Commission was scrapped on 13 August 2014. NITI Aayog (National Institution for Transforming India) was established on 1 January 2015 as its successor, by an executive resolution of the Union Cabinet.

NITI Aayog is India's premier policy "Think Tank," providing directional and policy inputs and pursuing a "Bharatiya approach to development."

TIMELINE

13 Aug 2014 — The Planning Commission (in existence for 65 years) is scrapped.

1 Jan 2015 — NITI Aayog is established by executive resolution of the Union Cabinet.

KEY DATA

Item	Fact
Full form	National Institution for Transforming India
Established	1 January 2015 (replaced the Planning Commission)
Nature	Non-constitutional & non-statutory (executive resolution)
Chairperson	Prime Minister

STATIC THEORY

- NITI Aayog replaces the Planning Commission's one-way, top-down, command-and-control flow with a bottom-up, collaborative partnership of states — cooperative federalism.

MEMORY HOOK

Planning Commission scrapped 13 Aug 2014 → NITI Aayog born 1 Jan 2015, both by executive resolution

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Planning Commission was scrapped on 13 August 2014, after 65 years in existence.
2. NITI Aayog was established on 1 January 2015 as its successor.
3. NITI Aayog was created by an executive resolution of the Union Cabinet, exactly like the Planning Commission before it.

MAINS ANGLE

Frame any NITI Aayog answer by first noting that both the Planning Commission and NITI Aayog share the same legal basis — executive resolution — which is why neither is constitutional or statutory.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Establishment

HIGH

2. Legal & Institutional Nature — Non-Constitutional, Non-Statutory

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Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

NITI Aayog is neither a constitutional nor a statutory body — it exists purely by an executive resolution of the Union Cabinet, just like the Planning Commission it replaced.

WHAT 'EXECUTIVE RESOLUTION' MEANS

NITI Aayog's Legal Basis

Not Constitutional No Article establishes NITI Aayog, unlike bodies such as the CAG or Finance Commission.	Not Statutory No Act of Parliament creates it, unlike UPSC or CAG's governing law.
Executive Resolution Created and can be altered/reconstituted by the Union Cabinet's own resolution.	Precedent This is the exact same legal basis on which the Planning Commission itself existed since inception.

STATIC THEORY

- ☐ Because it rests on executive resolution rather than the Constitution or a statute, NITI Aayog's structure and even its existence can be changed by the executive without a constitutional amendment or parliamentary legislation — exactly as happened to the Planning Commission in 2014.

MEMORY HOOK

No Article, no Act — only a Cabinet executive resolution creates and can reshape NITI Aayog

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog is neither a constitutional nor a statutory body.
2. It was created by an executive resolution of the Union Cabinet, the same basis on which the Planning Commission existed.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: NITI Aayog is a constitutional or statutory body.

CORRECT: It is neither — it rests solely on an executive resolution of the Union Cabinet.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the executive-resolution basis to explain why NITI Aayog, like the Planning Commission before it, can be restructured or replaced without any constitutional or legislative process.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Legal Status

HIGH

3. Composition I — Chairperson, Governing Council & Regional Councils

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INTRO & ORIGIN

At the apex sits the Prime Minister as Chairperson, supported by a Governing Council that brings every state and Union Territory into the process, and Regional Councils for multi-state issues.

KEY DATA

Component	Detail
Chairperson	The Prime Minister
Governing Council	CMs of all States + CMs of UTs with legislatures (Delhi, Puducherry, J&K;) + LGs of other UTs
Regional Councils	For issues spanning multiple States/regions; formed for a fixed tenure; convened by the PM

STATIC THEORY

- The Governing Council is the institutional embodiment of cooperative federalism — it brings every state and UT chief executive into NITI Aayog's decision-making, unlike the Planning Commission's more centralised structure.
- Regional Councils are convened for specific, time-bound, multi-state issues, not as permanent standing bodies.

MEMORY HOOK

PM chairs — Governing Council = all State CMs + UT (legislature) CMs + other UT LGs — Regional Councils = fixed-tenure, multi-state

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Prime Minister is the Chairperson of NITI Aayog.
2. The Governing Council includes CMs of all states, CMs of UTs with legislatures, and LGs of other UTs.
3. Regional Councils are formed for a fixed tenure and convened by the Prime Minister.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Governing Council excludes Union Territory chiefs.

CORRECT: It includes CMs of UTs with legislatures plus LGs of other UTs.

MAINS ANGLE

Cite the Governing Council's composition directly when arguing that NITI Aayog was institutionally designed to make states equal partners rather than passive recipients.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Composition (Chairperson & Governing Council)

HIGH**4. Composition II — Vice-Chairperson, Members & CEO**GS-II / GS-III
Indian Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Below the Chairperson and Governing Council, NITI Aayog's day-to-day leadership rests with a PM-appointed Vice-Chairperson, several categories of Members, and a Secretary-rank CEO.

KEY DATA

Role	Detail
Vice-Chairperson	Appointed by the PM; rank of Cabinet Minister
Full-time Members	Rank of Minister of State
Part-time Members	Maximum 2, from universities/research bodies, rotational basis
Ex-officio Members	Maximum 4 Union ministers, nominated by the PM
CEO	Appointed by the PM for a fixed tenure; rank of Secretary to the GoI

STATIC THEORY

- The rank structure (Cabinet Minister for Vice-Chairperson, Minister of State for full-time Members, Secretary for the CEO) mirrors government hierarchy, even though NITI Aayog itself is not a government department in the constitutional sense.

MEMORY HOOK

VC = Cabinet Minister rank | Full-time Member = MoS rank | Part-time ≤ 2 | Ex-officio ≤ 4 ministers | CEO = Secretary rank

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Vice-Chairperson is appointed by the PM and holds the rank of a Cabinet Minister.
2. Part-time Members are capped at 2, drawn from universities/research bodies on rotation.
3. Ex-officio Members are capped at 4 Union ministers, nominated by the PM.
4. The CEO is PM-appointed for a fixed tenure, with the rank of Secretary to the GoI.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Vice-Chairperson is elected, though holding Cabinet Minister rank.

CORRECT: The Vice-Chairperson is appointed by the Prime Minister.

MAINS ANGLE

When composition questions ask for numeric caps, remember: Part-time Members ≤ 2 , Ex-officio Members ≤ 4 — these caps are frequently tested as factual recall.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Composition (Vice-Chairperson, Members, CEO)

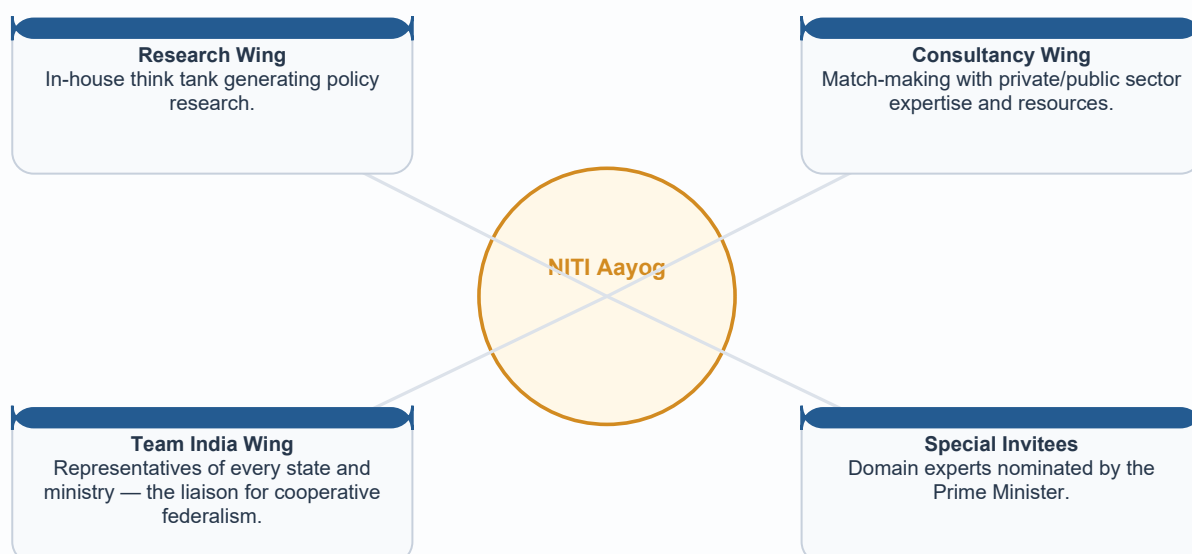
HIGH

5. Composition III — Special Invitees & Specialised Wings

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Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Beyond its formal membership, NITI Aayog draws in domain experts as Special Invitees and organises its working machinery into three specialised wings.

NITI AAYOG'S WORKING MACHINERY

STATIC THEORY

- The Research and Consultancy Wings supply NITI Aayog's knowledge/advisory capacity, while the Team India Wing operationalises cooperative federalism by directly linking every state and ministry into the institution.

MEMORY HOOK

Research (think) + Consultancy (match-make) + Team India (liaise with states/ministries) + Special Invitees (expertise)

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog's three specialised wings are the Research Wing, Consultancy Wing and Team India Wing.
2. Special Invitees are domain experts nominated by the Prime Minister.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the Team India Wing specifically when arguing that NITI Aayog institutionalises state and ministry participation, distinct from the Planning Commission's more centralised staffing.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Specialised Wings & Special Invitees

HIGH**6. Objectives & Core Functions — Four Pillars**

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INTRO & ORIGIN

NITI Aayog's mandate rests on four core functions that together define its role as an advisory, knowledge-driven institution rather than a fund-allocating authority.

NITI AAYOG'S FOUR CORE FUNCTIONS**NITI Aayog Functions**

Design Policy & Programme Framework Shapes national and sectoral policy direction.	Foster Cooperative Federalism Builds state partnership through the Governing Council and Team India Wing.
Monitoring & Evaluation Tracks implementation and outcomes of programmes.	Think-Tank / Knowledge & Innovation Hub Generates and disseminates policy knowledge and best practices.

STATIC THEORY

- These four functions map onto two operational hubs: policy design and cooperative federalism converge in the Team India Hub, while think-tank and knowledge work sit in the Knowledge & Innovation Hub (see Module 7).

MEMORY HOOK

Design → Federalism → Monitor → Think-Tank = NITI Aayog's four functions

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog's four core functions are: policy/programme design, fostering cooperative federalism, monitoring and evaluation, and functioning as a think-tank/knowledge hub.

MAINS ANGLE

Structure any 'role of NITI Aayog' answer around these four functions, then note the key limitation (Module 8) to keep the answer balanced.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Objectives & Functions

HIGH

7. Two Knowledge Hubs — Team India Hub & Knowledge and Innovation Hub

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INTRO & ORIGIN

NITI Aayog organises its four functions operationally into two hubs, translating mandate into working structure.

KEY DATA

Hub	Focus
Team India Hub	Cooperative federalism and policy design, working directly with states and ministries
Knowledge & Innovation Hub	Resource centre for best practices, functioning as the think-tank/knowledge function

STATIC THEORY

• The two-hub structure is the practical, day-to-day expression of the four core functions listed in Module 6 — useful for answers that ask 'how' NITI Aayog performs its functions, not just 'what' they are.

MEMORY HOOK

Team India Hub = federalism + policy design | Knowledge & Innovation Hub = think-tank + best practices

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog operates through two hubs: the Team India Hub and the Knowledge & Innovation Hub.

MAINS ANGLE

Reference the two-hub structure to show institutional mechanics behind NITI Aayog's stated functions, adding operational depth to a functions-only answer.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Team India Hub & Knowledge Hub

HIGH

8. Key Limitation — Advisory Role, No Fund-Allocation Power

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INTRO & ORIGIN

The single most tested feature of NITI Aayog is what it cannot do: it only recommends, and has no power to allocate funds — that authority moved to the Finance Ministry.

STATIC THEORY

• □ This advisory-only design is exactly why critics call NITI Aayog a 'toothless think tank' — see Module 12 for the fuller cooperative-vs-coercive federalism debate.

MEMORY HOOK

NITI Aayog recommends; the Finance Ministry allocates — no imposition power over states

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog only recommends — it has no power to allocate funds.
2. Fund-allocation authority now rests with the Finance Ministry.
3. NITI Aayog cannot impose its plans on states.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: NITI Aayog allocates funds/grants to states.

CORRECT: It is advisory only; fund allocation is with the Finance Ministry.

THE LIMITATION CHAIN

Concept	Linked Idea	Why It Matters
No fund-allocation power	Finance Ministry now allocates funds	NITI Aayog cannot back its recommendations with money, unlike the Planning Commission.
Cannot impose plans on states	Advisory-only relationship	States can accept or set aside NITI Aayog's recommendations without formal consequence.

MAINS ANGLE

Any answer praising NITI Aayog's cooperative-federalism design must be balanced with this fund-allocation limitation — examiners reward answers that show both sides.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Key Limitation

HIGH

9. Planning Commission vs NITI Aayog — Comparative Framework

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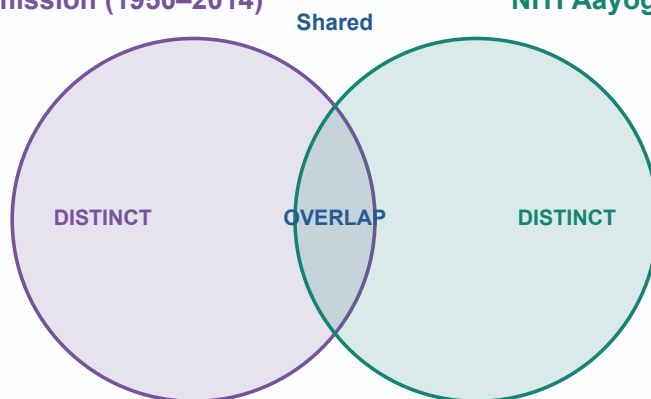
INTRO & ORIGIN

NITI Aayog was explicitly designed as an institutional contrast to the Planning Commission it replaced — same legal basis, opposite operating philosophy.

PLANNING COMMISSION VS NITI AAYOG

Planning Commission (1950–2014)

NITI Aayog (2015–)

**Planning Commission (1950–2014)**

- Allocated funds/grants to states
- Top-down (command) federal approach
- Imposed Five-Year Plans
- States were passive recipients

Shared

- Created by executive resolution
- Chaired at the highest political level
- Advises/shapes national policy direction

NITI Aayog (2015–)

- Advisory think tank — no fund allocation
- Bottom-up (cooperative) federal approach
- Strategy/vision documents, no imposition
- States are equal partners via the Governing Council

□ Members: the Planning Commission relied on full-time economists, while NITI Aayog is PM-led with CMs and outside experts — a further contrast beyond fund allocation.

KEY DATA

Point	Planning Commission (1950–2014)	NITI Aayog (2015–)
Basis	Executive resolution	Executive resolution
Role	Allocated funds/grants to states	Advisory think tank — no fund allocation
Federal approach	Top-down (command)	Bottom-up (cooperative)
Plans	Five-Year Plans (imposed)	Strategy/vision documents, no imposition

MEMORY HOOK

Same birth (executive resolution), opposite philosophy: allocate-and-command vs advise-and-cooperate

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Both bodies share the same legal basis — an executive resolution.
2. The Planning Commission allocated funds top-down; NITI Aayog only advises, bottom-up.
3. States were passive recipients under the Planning Commission but are equal partners in NITI Aayog's Governing Council.

MAINS ANGLE

'NITI Aayog replaced allocation with advice — has it strengthened or weakened planning?' Use this comparative table as the factual backbone, then add your own analytical judgment.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Comparison with Planning Commission

HIGH

10. From Five-Year Plans to Vision Documents

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INTRO & ORIGIN

The end of the Five-Year Plan era is a concrete marker of NITI Aayog's different planning philosophy — replacing imposed multi-year plans with layered advisory documents.

END OF FIVE-YEAR PLANS → NEW PLANNING DOCUMENTS



STATIC THEORY

- Five-Year Plans ended with the 12th Plan (2012–17); NITI Aayog replaced them with a 3-year Action Agenda, a 7-year Strategy and a 15-year Vision document.
- This layered short/medium/long-term structure itself signals a shift from a single rigid plan cycle to flexible, non-binding guidance documents.

MEMORY HOOK

12th Plan (2012–17) was the last — replaced by 3-yr Action, 7-yr Strategy, 15-yr Vision

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The 12th Five-Year Plan (2012–17) was the last Five-Year Plan.
2. NITI Aayog replaced Five-Year Plans with a 3-year Action Agenda, a 7-year Strategy and a 15-year Vision document.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: NITI Aayog still formulates Five-Year Plans.
CORRECT: Five-Year Plans ended with the 12th Plan (2012–17); NITI Aayog issues vision/strategy documents instead.

MAINS ANGLE

Cite the exact 3/7/15-year document structure as evidence of NITI Aayog's shift from binding plans to indicative, layered planning horizons.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → End of Five-Year Plans

HIGH

11. Flagship Tools & Current Affairs Anchors

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NEWS TRIGGER

NITI Aayog's monitoring tools and sectoral reports are a recurring current-affairs source for questions linking institutional design to real governance outcomes.

KEY DATA

Flagship Tool / CA Hook	Nature
SDG India Index	Monitoring tool tracking states'/UTs' progress on Sustainable Development Goals
Aspirational Districts / Aspirational Blocks Programme	Monitoring and convergence programme for lagging districts/blocks
Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)	Monitoring tool measuring poverty across multiple deprivation indicators
Development finance / green transition / AI strategy reports	Policy reports shaping current sectoral debates

STATIC THEORY

- ☐ These tools illustrate NITI Aayog's monitoring-and-evaluation and think-tank functions in practice — they are current-affairs-linked applications of the four core functions from Module 6, not separate powers.

MEMORY HOOK

SDG India Index + Aspirational Districts/Blocks + MPI = NITI's flagship monitoring tools

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The SDG India Index, the Aspirational Districts/Blocks Programme, and the Multidimensional Poverty Index are NITI Aayog's flagship monitoring tools.
2. NITI Aayog also produces reports on development finance, green transition and AI strategy that shape current policy.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the SDG India Index and Aspirational Districts/Blocks Programme as concrete evidence when an answer needs to show the monitoring-and-evaluation function in action, not just in theory.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Flagship Tools

HIGH

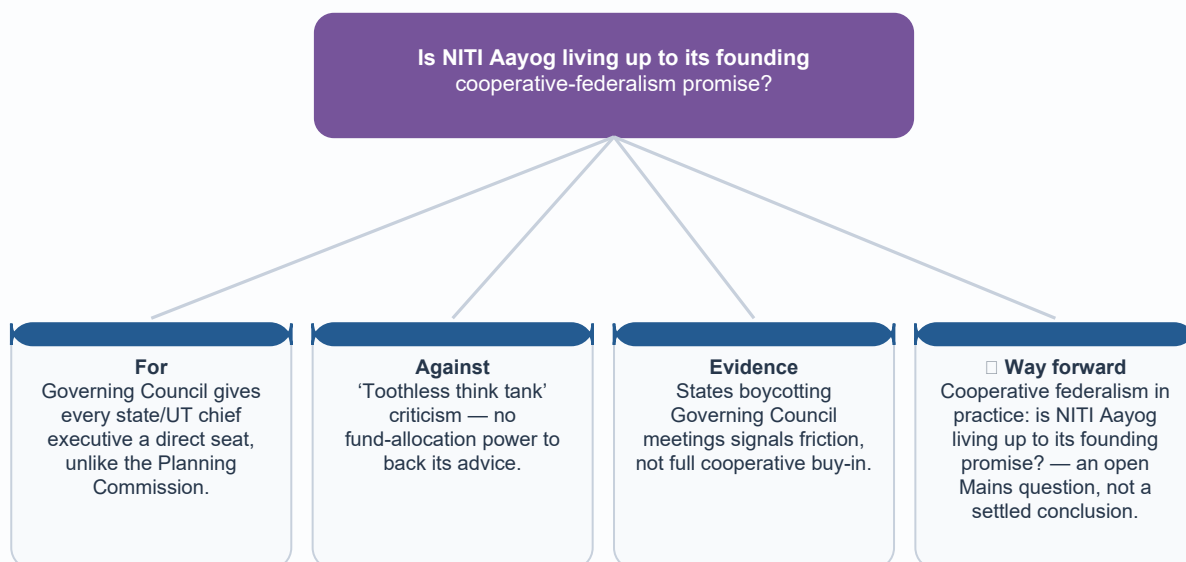
12. Cooperative vs Coercive Federalism Debate

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Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

NITI Aayog is criticised as a 'toothless think tank' without the Planning Commission's fund clout, feeding an ongoing cooperative-vs-coercive federalism debate, including instances of states boycotting Governing Council meetings.

IS NITI AAYOG STRENGTHENING COOPERATIVE FEDERALISM?



STATIC THEORY

- This debate is the natural synthesis of Modules 8 (fund-allocation limitation) and 9 (Planning Commission comparison) — always connect the 'toothless' criticism back to the absence of fund power.

MEMORY HOOK

Governing Council seat = cooperation | No fund power = 'toothless' criticism | State boycotts = friction evidence

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog is criticised as a 'toothless think tank' without the Planning Commission's fund clout.
2. This has fed a cooperative-vs-coercive federalism debate, including states boycotting Governing Council meetings.

MAINS ANGLE

'Cooperative federalism in practice: is NITI Aayog living up to its founding promise?' Use this argument tree to build a balanced answer citing the Governing Council's design against the toothless-think-tank criticism.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Federalism Debate

HIGH

13. Mains Framework & Integrated Recap

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INTRO & ORIGIN

A single consolidated map ties together establishment, composition, functions, limitation and the federalism debate for last-minute revision and answer-writing.

NITI AAYOG — ONE-PAGE RECALL MAP**NITI Aayog**

Origin Executive resolution; replaced Planning Commission, 1 Jan 2015.	Composition PM Chair; Governing Council of all States/UTs; VC, Members, CEO.
Functions Policy design, cooperative federalism, monitoring, think-tank — via two hubs.	Limitation & Debate No fund power; 'toothless think tank' vs cooperative federalism promise.

STATIC THEORY

- Revision order: origin/legal status → composition → functions/hubs → key limitation → Planning Commission comparison → flagship tools/CA → federalism debate.
- ☐ No verified PYQ is recorded for this topic in the source material — use the three Mains angles below (from the source) rather than a fabricated PYQ.

MEMORY HOOK

Executive resolution → PM + Governing Council → 4 functions/2 hubs → advise-only, no funds

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NITI Aayog is a non-constitutional, non-statutory body created by executive resolution, replacing the Planning Commission from 1 January 2015.
2. It is chaired by the Prime Minister, with a Governing Council of all State CMs, relevant UT CMs, and other UT LGs.
3. Its four core functions operate through the Team India Hub and the Knowledge & Innovation Hub.
4. Its central limitation is that it only recommends — fund allocation rests with the Finance Ministry.

MAINS ANGLE

Three ready Mains angles from the source: (1) Has NITI Aayog strengthened or weakened planning by replacing allocation with advice? (2) Is NITI Aayog living up to its cooperative-federalism promise in practice? (3) Assess the vacuum in India's planning architecture after the Planning Commission.

STUDY LINK

Polity → NITI Aayog → Integrated Recap